

CONVERSATIONS WITH CHATGPT I: FILM GENRES

MR: Drawing on Rick Altman's influential 1980s Cinema Journal article on film genres, explain in simple terms the difference between semantic and syntagmatic elements in film genres.

Semantic elements are the **building blocks you can point to directly** in a film.

These are things like settings, costumes, props, character types, iconography, and recurring visual/audio cues. In a western, for example, that might mean horses, saloons, six-shooters, deserts, sheriffs, and outlaws. Altman's point is that one way people identify genre is by noticing these repeated surface elements.

Syntagmatic elements are the **way those building blocks are arranged into relationships and patterns**.

This is less about what is present than about **how it functions in the narrative**: what kinds of conflicts appear, what oppositions structure the story, what roles characters play in relation to one another, and what kind of plot logic holds the film together. In a western, for instance, it is not just that there is a sheriff and an outlaw, but that the film organizes them into a conflict about law, order, community, frontier violence, and justice.

A very plain way to put it is:

- **Semantic = the genre's vocabulary**
- **Syntagmatic = the genre's grammar**

So if you look at a **gangster film** semantically, you notice guns, suits, nightclubs, city streets, mob bosses, and get-away cars.

If you look at it syntagmatically, you ask how the story is organized: often around rise and fall, loyalty and betrayal, ambition and punishment, or the tension between the individual criminal and the social order.

Why Altman thinks the distinction matters:

He argues that some critics define genres mainly by **shared images and motifs** while others define them by **shared narrative structure and meaning**. His "semantic/syntactic approach" tries to combine both, because either one on its own is too limited. A film may look like a genre film on the surface but organize its story differently, or it may use an unusual surface style while still following a familiar genre structure.

So the core distinction is:

Semantic asks: "What familiar genre ingredients are here?"

Syntagmatic asks: "How are those ingredients structured into a meaningful pattern?"

Rick Altman says we can think about genre in two different ways. **Semantic elements** are the things we can easily spot in a film: the typical setting, objects, costumes, character types, and images. A western, for instance, has guns, horses, saloons, sheriffs, outlaws, and open frontier landscapes. These are the genre's visible ingredients. Altman argues that many genre definitions stop at this level: they identify a genre by its recurring icons and motifs.

But **syntagmatic elements** are about how those ingredients are organized into a pattern. This means the kinds of relationships, conflicts, and plot structures that hold the film together. In a western, it is not just that there is a sheriff and an outlaw; it is that the story often stages a conflict between law and lawlessness, wilderness and settlement, individual violence and social order. So semantics are the genre's **materials**, while syntax is the genre's **structure**. Altman's main point is that we understand genre best when we look at both together, not just one or the other.

And here are **examples**:

Horror

Semantically, horror gives you recognizable things: haunted houses, monsters, shadows, knives, screams, dark basements, vulnerable bodies. Syntagmatically, horror often organizes these into a structure of threat, pursuit, revelation, and survival. So the monster is not just present as an image; it occupies a structural role in a story about fear, danger, and the breakdown of safety.

Film noir

Semantically, noir includes rain-slicked streets, nightclubs, trench coats, cigarettes, venetian-blind shadows, urban settings, and femmes fatales. Syntagmatically, noir often arranges these into narratives of entrapment, moral ambiguity, doomed desire, betrayal, and fatalism. So a noir is not just a set of dark images; it is also a story pattern in which characters are caught in corrupt systems and bad choices.

The musical

Semantically, musicals include songs, dance numbers, performance spaces, orchestration, and spectacle. Syntagmatically, they organize these elements so that song and dance become part of the film's emotional or narrative logic: characters sing when feelings intensify, conflicts are transformed into performance, and narrative development is often carried by musical expression. That is why a film with songs in it is not automatically a musical; the songs have to function structurally in a particular way.

The shortest usable formula is:

Semantic = what a genre contains

Syntagmatic = how a genre is organized